

Family that fled Russian army, communism tell tale of survival and undying love

Ruth Rems and Anna MacArthur were interviewed and photographed in Rems' Quincy home by Herald-Whig Photo Editor Philip Carlson. *The Quincy Herald Whig*, page 12A, Friday, October 31, 2008. "Perspective" Section.



Anna MacArthur, left, and her mother, Ruth Rems, hold a document written by Anna's father and Ruth's late husband, Peter Rems, indicating the various cities across the United States he thought the family could settle in after enduring great hardship in the years after World War II in Germany. The family eventually settled in Lima [Illinois].

Ruth Rems and her daughter Anna MacArthur sat Monday in the living room of Ruth's Quincy home. The year was 2008, but once the pair began talking, it was 1944 all over again. That's the year they fled their homeland of Latvia from the invading Russian army and the Soviet Union's communist regime. "I've gone over it, what our country was like when we left from communists," Ruth said. "A long journey. My, my, my." Ruth's husband, the late Peter Rems, was wanted for spreading anti-communist

propaganda. My father had a horrendous life,” Anna recalled. “He was beaten and shot. Starved.” The family fled across the countryside before ending up in Germany, where Peter was eventually captured. “This didn’t happen in just a few weeks or months, Anna said. “It was two or three years. I was left with different people while my mother was trying to search for him.” They eventually found each other, and timing played a remarkable part. The family came to the U.S., settled in Lima and then moved to Quincy. Peter worked as a carpenter at Gardner Denver Co. He died June 10, 2007, at age 97.

RR: From there, we didn’t sleep at home. We slept in fields. Latvia is cold in May, June. One house, they took everything. They took all the food away, then they burned the family of six the same night. The whole family was burned. Parents and kids and all. Another (family), they put in a wagon, chained them all together with the parents, and drove them someplace to kill.

AM: Those were neighbors. And you must remember, back then, the communists ... anybody that had any brains, anybody that did their own thinking, they tried to destroy everything. All the intelligent people. Doctors, lawyers, they would take them into their (political) party and say, “Either do what we say or you’re going to die.” It’s like a scene in the movies, and you can’t fathom any of this because you’re too young to know what the heck went on after World War II.

For whatever reason, they pursued my dad, for whatever reason, the communists, even in Germany, were looking for my dad. He was captured by the Russians. We were hiding, and I remember what he told me. He was in some town, and of course, the building sections were all bombed. And he saw the Russians, and he went to hide in one of these buildings, and somebody in another building across the street saw him and said, “He’s over there, he’s over there.” Because back then it was you were against your brother, your father, your mother, anybody that you could, because it

was give (the Russians) information or you die. And that's how they got my dad the first time. And my dad escaped from an army transport truck, and that's when he got shot and ended up in the hospital.

RR: They started investigating him and said he was a spy, and here this Russian car comes to take him away. They didn't know what to do. The American people, they got to him and translated. He said, "I left my family," where he left us, you know? And then they pushed the Russians away and took Peter and put him in the hospital in the American zone. He was in the hospital in Linz, Austria. The nurse came to him one day, and said: "Mr. Rems, this is in the chart. When you get better we are supposed to give you to the Russians." Peter, he didn't sleep. The next day, the nurse said she would do something. Well, she got the chart, and she destroyed it. The doctor didn't even see it. She destroyed his papers. When he got out, he didn't know where I am now. No idea. He went into Munich, every office. No name, no name. Nothing.

I said: "what am i doing here? Germany is not my country. What do I do with these kids. No relations with me." And I went to the Russian camp. They signed me in and welcomed me very, very good. They never asked whether I had a husband or whatever. And I signed (up) to go home. There was a lady downstairs, and I took my suitcase down there and put it in her closet. Then Peter was looking for us, and he found a woman who went to the Russian camp (to look for us). She went around (looking). I opened the door, and she was there, and she gave me a little piece of paper.

She gave me the paper, and i read it. And Peter said: "I am over here. Can you get out and come to such and such place?" And I was already free. I had signed to go home, you know? Or Siberia, maybe. And I had a waiter to wait on me. And this waiter, he was very good to me. And he said: "Madam, what's wrong with you? Is something wrong with you?" And I didn't know whether I should tell him. So I said I am going to tell him my husband is here and looking for me. And he offered to help me. We were

on the sixth floor, no elevator. I had already prepared the baby buggy with clothes for the baby. So I gave him the buggy, and here were all these Russian military, with the stars, all generals, going up (the stairs). And they said, "Madam, are you going for a walk?" And I said, "Yes, I am going for a walk."

My walk was goodbye. I get the baby buggy around the corner, Peter was waiting someplace, a coffee shop, and we took a streetcar to some friends' house. The (Russian officials) had told me, "The train is going tomorrow." Monday. Back to Latvia. Or Siberia. And Peter found me Sunday. He found me at the last minute.

[end]